English Book II — Class 12 (PCTB, English Medium)

Solved Exercises | Punjab Curriculum and Textbook Board | Lessons 1-16

EXTENDED EDITION — Book exercises (verbatim 'Answer these questions') are now complete for ALL Lessons 1-16. Earlier comprehension selections are retained.

Lesson 1: The Dying Sun — Sir James Jeans

Comprehension questions

What is the dying sun? How will it affect the earth?

The dying sun means the sun cooling down and losing its heat over millions of years.

When the sun dies, the earth will receive no heat and light from it.

The oceans will freeze and all life on earth will come to an end.

The lesson describes this distant future of the solar system.

How did the planets come into existence according to the lesson?

According to the lesson, a wandering star once passed close to the sun.

Its gravitational pull tore out a filament of matter from the sun.

This matter broke into pieces which cooled and became the planets.

The earth is one of these pieces, which later cooled enough for life to appear.

Why does the writer say that life on earth is a brief incident?

Life appeared on earth only after it cooled for millions of years.

It will end when the sun cools and the earth freezes again.

Compared with the vast age of the universe, the period of life is very short.

Man should therefore value life and use his time wisely.

What will happen to the sun in the far future?

The sun is slowly losing its heat by radiation into space.

After millions of years it will become a cold, dark body.

The planets will then wander in darkness without heat or light.

This is the picture of the dying sun given by Sir James Jeans.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

How is it that a star seldom finds another star near it?

The stars travel through a universe so immense that one star very rarely comes near another.

In a scale model where the stars are ships, the average ship is well over a million miles from its nearest neighbour.

Each star therefore makes its voyage in almost complete loneliness, like a ship on an empty ocean.

That is why a star seldom finds another star near it.

What happened when, according to Sir James Jeans, a wandering star, wandering through space, came near the sun?

Some two thousand million years ago a wandering star happened to come near the sun.

Just as the sun and moon raise tides on the earth, the second star raised tides on the surface of the sun.

An immense tidal wave travelled over the surface of the sun and formed a mountain so high that we can hardly imagine it.

This mountain was the beginning of the planets.

What happened when the wandering star came nearer and nearer?

As the disturbing star came nearer and nearer, the mountain on the sun rose higher and higher.

Before the second star began to move away again, its tidal pull became so powerful that the mountain was torn to pieces.

Small parts of the mountain were thrown off into space.

These small pieces have been going round the sun ever since, and they are the planets.

What are planets and how did they come into existence?

Planets are the small pieces of the sun that were thrown off into space.

They came into existence when a wandering star raised an immense tidal mountain on the sun and tore it to pieces.

The pieces cooled gradually until they had very little heat of their own left.

Our earth is one of these pieces, and its warmth now comes almost entirely from the sun's radiation.

Why is there no life on the stars?

The stars are extremely hot, far too hot for life to exist on them.

Most of the matter in space is either so hot that life on it is impossible or so cold that all life in it would be frozen.

Life needs a temperature at which substances can exist in a liquid state.

The stars themselves are far too hot for this, so there is no life on them.

Write a note on the beginning of life on the earth.

In course of time one of the cooling pieces thrown off from the sun gave birth to life.

We do not know how, when or why this happened.

It started in simple organisms whose living power consisted chiefly in being able to reproduce themselves before dying.

From these humble beginnings came a stream of life which grew more and more complex, until it produced beings centred in feelings, ambitions, a sense of beauty and religion.

Why is the universe, of which our earth is a part, so frightening? Give as many

reasons as you can.

The universe is frightening because of its immense distances which we do not understand.

It is frightening because of the stretches of time so great that we cannot imagine them, making the whole of human history very small in comparison.

It is frightening because of our extreme loneliness and the littleness of our home in space, a millionth part of a grain of sand out of all the sea-sand in the world.

Above all, it is frightening because we cannot find any sign that life like our own exists anywhere in it except on the earth.

What, in your opinion, should be the conditions necessary, for the kind of life we know to exist on other heavenly bodies? Do such conditions generally exist?

Life of the kind we know needs a temperature that is neither too hot nor too cold, so that substances can exist in a liquid state.

It can exist only in a narrow belt surrounding each star at a certain distance: outside the belt life would be frozen and inside it would be burnt up.

Such conditions do not generally exist: all such temperature belts together make up less than a thousand million millionth part of the whole of space.

Probably only one star in 100,000 has a planet going round it at the right distance for life to be possible on it.

Lesson 2: Using the Scientific Method — Darrel Barnard and Lon Edwards

Comprehension questions

What is the scientific method?

The scientific method is an orderly way of solving problems.

It begins with observing facts and stating the problem clearly.

Then a hypothesis, or possible explanation, is formed.

The hypothesis is tested by experiments, and a conclusion is drawn from the results.

What are the steps of the scientific method?

The first step is to observe and collect facts about the problem.

The second step is to form a hypothesis to explain the facts.

The third step is to test the hypothesis by controlled experiments.

The last step is to accept, reject or revise the hypothesis according to the results.

Why is a control experiment necessary?

A control experiment keeps all conditions the same except the one being tested.

It shows whether the change is really caused by the factor under test.

Without a control, the result could be due to some other cause.

It therefore makes the conclusion of the experiment reliable.

How does the scientific method help in daily life?

It teaches us to think clearly instead of accepting claims blindly.

We learn to test ideas by facts before believing them.

It helps in solving practical problems, from cooking to repairing machines.

A scientific attitude thus makes life more rational and successful.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

How has the scientific method helped us in our fight against disease?

Two hundred years ago about seven out of eight babies died before reaching their first birthday.

A child who survived was likely to have smallpox before six, and measles, whooping cough, scarlet fever and diphtheria by twelve, while yellow fever, malaria, typhus, cholera, typhoid fever and influenza spread through communities.

Today babies are born in hospitals where there is little likelihood of their getting a disease, and young people are treated to protect them against smallpox, diphtheria and typhoid fever.

A person can now expect to live to almost seventy years, so more than thirty years have been added to the expected length of man's life by the scientific study of the causes of disease and its prevention.

Write a note on the better sanitary conditions available in our cities today and compare them with what they were like a hundred years ago.

A hundred years ago city streets were narrow, unpaved and poorly drained, and household garbage and refuse were thrown into them.

Animals wandered through the streets feeding on the garbage, outdoor toilets were common, and many were situated where human wastes drained into wells from which people obtained drinking water.

Today city streets are paved and well drained and are cleaned regularly, and it is against the law to throw garbage in the streets.

Sewage from all sections of a city is carried through sealed pipes to disposal plants, and most city governments have departments of sanitation which keep the cities clean and prevent the spread of diseases like typhoid fever, cholera and dysentery.

What are the sanitary conditions like in our villages today and how would you improve them?

Applying the lesson's city measures to villages, many villages still lack the paved, well-drained streets, sealed sewage disposal and safe piped water that cities now enjoy.

Where garbage is thrown in the open and wastes drain near wells, the same diseases the lesson names, typhoid fever, cholera and dysentery, can spread.

Villages can be improved by paving and draining streets, cleaning them regularly, and carrying sewage through sealed pipes to disposal plants.

Safe water systems, sanitation departments and the lesson's rule that unsanitary conditions cause disease should be applied in villages exactly as in cities.

How has the scientific method helped us in the production and preservation of foods?

Through science we have learned that it is healthful to eat many kinds of food, and we have learned how to provide a variety of foods throughout the year.

A century ago most foods had to be produced on one's own farm or garden, and fresh vegetables could be obtained only during the growing season.

Thrifty housewives preserved vegetables and fruits by canning, pickling or drying, and meats by salting, drying or freezing when the weather was cold enough.

Today, by the quick-freeze method, vegetables, fruits, seafoods and meats can be preserved so that they are both nutritious and enjoyable, and modern selecting, grading and processing, including dehydration of milk, eggs, potatoes and apples, have removed the risk of poisoning from canned foods.

We are now generally less fearful than our ancestors. What were our ancestors afraid of?

Our ancestors were afraid of happenings they could not explain, which used to be considered strange and mysterious.

They feared diseases which spread through communities and killed large numbers of people, and many believed diseases were caused by evil spirits.

They feared signs of good or bad luck, and believed that wearing a charm could prevent bad luck.

They feared things like black cats, broken mirrors and the number 13, and their lives were greatly influenced by such signs.

How has the scientific method enabled us to get over the old fears?

The scientific method has demonstrated that there is always a good natural reason for everything that happens to people.

It has shown that superstitious beliefs have no sound basis, so few people today believe that diseases are caused by evil spirits.

Ideas are no longer accepted merely because they have been believed for a long time; they must now be supported by facts.

The discoveries of scientists have also developed open-mindedness, so people are more willing to look for new truths and less likely to accept conclusions as final.

What part did astrology play in the lives of men and women in the past? Give examples.

Astrology is the observation of the stars in the belief that their motion has an effect on man's life.

In the past it played a large part in people's lives: they looked to the stars and to fortune-telling for guidance about their affairs.

They believed in signs of good or bad luck, and a person who believed that wearing a charm would prevent bad luck would wear it and feel uncomfortable without it.

Though astrology and fortune-telling are still practised, the lesson says they do not influence the lives of as many people as they once did.

Describe some of the superstitions still current in our country. How do they affect the lives of those who believe in them?

Superstitions still current include fear of black cats, broken mirrors and the number 13.

Some people still wear charms in the belief that a charm will prevent bad luck, and astrology and fortune-telling are still practised.

Those who believe in them let signs of good or bad luck greatly influence their lives.

A believer feels uncomfortable without his charm, and his feelings and actions are governed by fears which the scientific method has shown to have no sound basis.

Lesson 3: Why Boys Fail in College — Herbert E. Hawkes

Comprehension questions

What are the main reasons why boys fail in college, according to Hawkes?

The main reasons are foolishness, sickness and lack of money.

Some boys fail because they do not take their studies seriously.

Others fall ill and cannot keep up with their classes.

Some have to work to earn money and cannot give full time to study.

What does Hawkes mean by 'a boy who does not know what college is for'?

Such a boy has no clear purpose in joining college.

He drifts into college without knowing what he wants to learn.

He wastes time in sports, societies and other distractions.

Without a purpose, he cannot concentrate and finally fails.

How can a boy avoid failure in college?

He should first decide clearly why he is in college.

He should work regularly and give full attention to his studies.

He should keep good health and avoid wasting time and money.

With purpose, hard work and self-discipline, he can succeed.

What is the role of the college dean in helping failing boys?

The dean studies each failing boy like a physician studies a patient.

He finds the real cause of failure, whether foolishness, sickness or poverty.

He then advises the boy and helps him remove that cause.

If he can save boys from failure through foolishness, sickness and sin, he is doing his part.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

According to the author there are some boys who fail because they do not try. Who

are they? Can we help them?

The first is the nervous boy who sits down to study, opens his book, and then sharpens his pencil, then all his pencils, until his time is gone and nothing has been done.

The second is the boy who follows a direction mapped out by his parents that runs counter to all his interests and abilities, and so cannot bring himself to try work that is distasteful to him.

The third is the very bright boy who has always done his school work without effort and supposes he can float through college with as little effort.

We can help only up to a point: others can see the difficulty and point out what is the matter, and a college alive to its work of advice can catch such cases before failure is complete, but the cure, a change of attitude and habits, can be made by the boy himself alone.

How does mistaken ambition on the part of boys and their parents lead to the failure of the boys?

A boy may show no interest in his work and not try to do it with distinction because he is following a direction mapped out by his parents.

For example, the parents intend him to be a physician, a dentist or an engineer, while he wants to be a theatrical manager, a businessman or a book-illustrator.

He has ability enough, but he does not want that profession, and reason cannot control such matters, any more than arguing can make a person like onions when he detests them.

If such a boy fails, it is because he cannot bring himself to try to do work that is distasteful to him and that he feels is leading him in the wrong direction.

There are some boys who have done well at school but fail to make their mark at college. Who are they? Do you have such boys in college in your country?

They are the very bright boys who have always done their school work without

effort and have never learned what real application is.

They suppose they can float through college with as little effort as they did through school, and Hawkes calls the bright boy who has always depended on his ability to get things quickly the most pitiable object among all failing students.

The cure involves an entire change of attitude and the forming of a completely new set of habits, which no one can do but the boy himself.

Yes, such boys are found in colleges in every country, including our own, wherever school success without steady study habits is mistaken for readiness for college work.

How does financial pressure lead to the failure of students described in the lesson? Do you have similar cases in your country?

Many boys are cast entirely on their own resources for their college expenses, and this is always to the detriment of their health, or the value of their education, or both.

The lesson describes boys taking jobs from six o'clock in the evening till two in the morning, six days a week, and even undergoing transfusion of blood to get money for food and books.

A boy who must earn his entire way gets a mighty poor living and a mighty poor education, and many boys of finest character and excellent ability are obliged to drop out for the lack of a little money to see them through.

Yes, similar cases exist in our country too, where students work long hours to pay fees and living costs, and scholarship funds, though helpful, cannot remove every such case.

To what extent does the question of health lead to failure at college? How far can the college authorities with their medical officers help students in such cases?

The question of health, both physical and mental, is always one of the reasons for failure.

If an adequate health service is available and proper cooperation exists between the teaching staff and the college doctor, an immense number of failures can be avoided.

In poor academic work where the reason is not apparent, Hawkes always asks the student to undergo a thorough physical examination, and the university physician often finds an adequate reason, such as tuberculosis, bad tonsils, sleeping sickness, poor digestion, or mental and nervous difficulty.

The lesson gives the case of a father who refused his son's tonsil operation, so the boy, absorbing too much poison to apply himself to college work, had to be sent home; there is no substitute for health, and knowledge is of little value without the physical vigour to bring it to bear on the world's problems.

What place would you accord to sportsmen in colleges?

Athletic sports and literary activity have their place in college life and should receive the support of students interested in them.

If a boy is too much interested in these side shows, Hawkes says he ought to get out of the main tent and become professional.

Most of them, however, are not too much interested, and if reasoned with by a friend who knows youth and understands the college opportunity, they will not allow themselves to be swept off their feet by athletics.

Hawkes does not think this is as serious a reason for failure as some outside critics of colleges suppose.

There are some students who join college for the fun of it. Should they be allowed to stay?

They are the lazy bluffers who drift into college and usually drift out again, having found no serious interest in life.

It is usually wise to let them retire to the cold world for a season and find out by experience how much demand there is for a lazy bluffer.

Sometimes they learn their lesson and return to do first-rate work.

But the burden of proof is always on them to show that they mean business, so they should not simply be allowed to stay and waste the college opportunity.

Lesson 4: End of Term — David Daiches

Comprehension questions

What does the writer remember about the end of term at school?

The writer remembers the excitement of the last day of term.

Boys packed their boxes, said goodbye to friends and waited for the holidays.

The school, which had seemed like a prison, suddenly became dear to them.

They felt both joy at going home and sadness at leaving school.

Why did school seem different on the last day of term?

During the term, school discipline and lessons felt like a burden.

On the last day, the burden was lifted and boys saw school with fresh eyes.

Teachers seemed kinder and the building itself looked beautiful.

The feeling of parting made them realise how much school had meant to them.

What is the main idea of 'End of Term'?

The lesson shows how we value things only when we are about to lose them.

School life, though hard, becomes precious in memory.

The end of term brings both freedom and a sense of loss.

The writer looks back at his school days with affection and nostalgia.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What was the Daiches' attitude towards the weekend as a school boy? Why did he long for it?

The phrase 'Friday Thank God' expresses perfectly his attitude to the arrival of the weekend during term time.

The daily grind of school, with its abundant homework, its fierce competition and the sense of never being able to relax, pressed heavily upon him.

Waking up in the morning with the knowledge that he simply had to get out of bed, with no possibility of an extra doze, and seeing the hours of school stretching ahead, was a dismal experience, especially on a Monday.

He longed for the weekend because Friday morning was positively rose-coloured, the last period on Friday had its special happy flavour, and he walked home on Friday afternoon with the tread of an escaped prisoner.

What was his general view of school life?

Though he often enjoyed the actual classroom work, the oppressive weight of the knowledge of a full day's school ahead remained a characteristic sensation of his childhood.

The anticipation was always worse than the reality, and he does not remember ever being especially unhappy in class.

That oppressive feeling disappeared only after he had left school and entered the university.

There the smaller number of classes to be attended and the freedom of the student to come and go meant a completely new kind of academic world.

He liked holidays for their freedom — freedom from what?

He liked holidays for their freedom from the daily grind of school.

They freed him from abundant homework, fierce competition and the sense of never being able to relax.

They freed him from having to get out of bed in the morning and facing a full day's school stretching ahead.

That is why walking home on Friday afternoon felt like the tread of an escaped

prisoner, and why the summer holidays, two months' vacation, were the time towards which the whole year moved.

How did he spend his summer holidays?

The summer holidays were the two months' vacation in the summer time, towards which the whole year moved.

He would walk home across the Meadows in the July sunshine, wearing his summer school clothes of grey cricket shirt, grey shorts and red Wetson's blazer, and savour his happiness with conscious relish.

Two months seemed a long, long time in those days, and he felt he could look forward to a period of permanent felicity.

At last the family stood by the trunks and suitcases outside No. 6, Millerfield Place, waiting for the taxi that was to convey the family and its luggage to the railway station.

Wishes don't come true in this life, writes Daiches. What are the things he longed for but could not have?

All his early childhood he longed desperately for a tricycle, which his parents could never afford.

Later the wish was transferred to a bicycle, and there too he was permanently disappointed; he bought his first bicycle for himself only when he was twenty-one, with prize money won at Edinburgh University.

He often stood outside sweet shops with empty pockets, longing for a penny or two to materialize somehow.

He hung on the outskirts of a crowd around an ice-cream barrow, wondering whether the ice-cream man would be miraculously inspired to offer him a 'cornet' or a 'slider' free, but these things never happened.

What did he do with his pocket money?

The few pence a week of pocket money they received was to be put into a money

box and saved.

During their early childhood, Lionel, Sylvia and he never had anything to spend for themselves.

The money was saved, not spent on the sweets and ice-creams he longed for.

That is why he stood outside sweet shops with empty pockets, longing for a penny or two.

Lesson 5: On Destroying Books — J. C. Squire

Comprehension questions

Why does Squire say that destroying books is a serious matter?

Books carry the thoughts, knowledge and experience of mankind.

To destroy a book is to destroy a part of human civilisation.

Even a bad book may contain something useful for future readers.

That is why Squire treats the destruction of books as a grave loss.

What kinds of books does Squire think may be destroyed, and why?

He admits that some books are useless, like out-of-date directories and guides.

Such books may be destroyed when they no longer serve any purpose.

But books of literature, history and thought must be preserved.

We cannot judge today what future generations will find valuable.

What is Squire's attitude toward books?

Squire loves books and treats them with respect and affection.

He believes every book deserves a chance to survive.

He is pained by the careless destruction of books.

His essay is a plea for the preservation of books and knowledge.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What sort of books were presented by the British public to soldiers?

Over two million volumes were presented to the troops by the public.

Most of them, no doubt, were quite ordinary and suitable.

But among them were such things as magazines twenty years old, guides to the Lake District, and back numbers of Whitaker's Almanac.

Squire calls such books indigestibles: in some cases they got into the parcels by accident, but in others people jumped at the opportunity of getting rid of books they did not want.

Was it interest of soldiers that prompted their action, or was it the wish to get rid of useless books?

It was the wish to get rid of useless books, not the soldiers' interest, that prompted the action.

Squire says it is likely that there are those who jump at the opportunity of getting rid of books they do not want.

He asks why they have kept them if they do not want them, and answers that most people, especially non-bookish people, are very reluctant to throw away anything that looks like a book.

The parcels for the troops gave such people a welcome chance to clear out their useless volumes.

Why should bad books be destroyed?

It is not merely absurd to keep rubbish merely because it is printed; it is positively a public duty to destroy it.

Destruction makes more room for new books.

It also saves one's heirs the trouble of sorting out the rubbish or storing it.

Bad books, therefore, should be destroyed rather than kept on shelves for ever.

Why is it difficult to destroy books?

Books may not have as many lives as a cat, but they certainly die hard, and it is sometimes difficult to find a scaffold for them.

This difficulty once brought Squire almost within the shadow of the rope, that is, within fear of being hanged, when he carried his books out at night.

A book cannot easily be burnt: it is almost as hopeless to try to burn a book without opening it as to try to burn a piece of granite.

That is why destroying books, though a public duty, is in practice a difficult and furtive business.

Why could not the author burn the unwanted books?

No one would have bought these books of inferior, minor verse, so he had to throw them away or wipe them off the map altogether.

He had no kitchen range, and he could not toast them on the gas-cooker.

He could not consume them leaf by leaf in his small study fire, for it is almost as hopeless to burn a book without opening it as to burn a piece of granite.

There were scores of them, so burning them one by one was out of the question.

How did he decide to get rid of them?

In the end he determined to do to them what so many people do to kittens: tie them up and consign them to the river.

He improvised a sack, stuffed the books into it, put it over his shoulder, and went down the stairs into the darkness.

It was nearly midnight as he stepped into the street, with a cold nip in the air and the sky full of stars.

He turned up his overcoat collar, settled the sack comfortably across his shoulders, and strode off towards the bridge to Battersea.

Describe the author's midnight venture to throw the books in the river and the suspicions which his action were likely to arouse.

A few doors down he passed a policeman flashing his lantern on the catches of

basement windows, and he fancied the policeman looked suspicious, so that he trembled slightly.

The thought occurred to him: 'Perhaps he suspects I have swag in this sack', though he knew he could bear investigation and nobody would suspect him of having stolen such goods.

At the Embankment he leaned against the parapet and looked down into the faintly luminous swirls of the river, but a step near him made him spring back and walk on with an air of rumination and unconcern.

Then came the thought that stopped him: 'What about the splash?' A man leaning at midnight over the Embankment wall, a sudden fling of his arms and a great splash in the water would make whoever was within sight and hearing rush at him and seize him, in all probability thinking it was a baby, and no constable would believe he had come out in the cold to get rid of a pack of poetry.

How did he muster up courage at last to fling them into the river?

He strayed up and down, increasingly fearful of being watched, summoning up his courage to take the plunge and quailing from it at the last moment.

At last he left the Embankment and hastened straight for the first of the projecting circular bays with seats on Chelsea Bridge.

When he reached it he knelt on the seat and hesitated again, but he had reached the turning point.

He thought savagely: 'What! Under the resolute mask that you show your friends is there really a shrinking and contemptible coward? If you fall now, you must never hold your head up again. Anyhow, what if you are hanged for it? Good God: you worm, better men than you have gone to the gallows.' With the courage of despair he took a heave, and the sack dropped sheer with a vast splash.

Did he come to have a feeling for those books once he had got rid of them?

Yes, he walked home thinking a little sadly of all those books falling into the cold

torrent, settling slowly down through the pitchy dark, and subsiding at last on the ooze of the bottom.

There they were to lie forlorn and forgotten whilst the unconscious world of men went on.

He addresses them directly: 'Horrible bad books, poor innocent books, you are lying there still, covered, perhaps, with mud by this time, with only a stray rag of your sacking sticking out of the slime into the opaque brown tides.'

He names them, Odes to Diana, Sonnets to Ethel, Dramas on the Love of Lancelot, Stanzas on a First Glimpse of Venice, and says they lie there in a living death, and their fate is perhaps worse than they deserved.

Lesson 6: The Man Who Was a Hospital — Jerome K. Jerome

Comprehension questions

Why does the writer call himself 'a hospital'?

The writer once read a medical book and imagined he had every disease in it.

He felt he had symptoms of all the diseases described, except housemaid's knee.

He therefore thought his body was like a hospital full of diseases.

The title is a humorous description of his imaginary illnesses.

What happened when the writer went to see a doctor?

The doctor examined him carefully and found nothing seriously wrong.

He advised him to eat well, drink less and take exercise.

He told him to stop reading medical books and imagining diseases.

The writer followed the advice and felt better, though he still feared illness.

What is the humorous point of the lesson?

The lesson laughs at people who imagine diseases after reading about them.

The writer's fears are imaginary, but he describes them very seriously.

His visit to the doctor shows that his real disease was worry.

Jerome teaches us, through humour, not to be hypochondriacs.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

How did Jerome K. Jerome come to suspect that his liver was out of order? What were the diseases he thought he was suffering from on reading a book on the treatment of diseases?

He had just been reading a patent liver-pill circular which listed the symptoms by which a man could tell when his liver was out of order, and he found he had them all.

At the British Museum he went to read up the treatment for a slight ailment, hay fever, and idly turned to studying diseases in general.

Going through the book alphabetically, he concluded he had typhoid fever, St. Vitus's Dance, Bright's disease in a modified form, cholera with severe complications and diphtheria.

He plodded through all twenty-six letters and found he had every known malady in the pharmacology except housemaid's knee.

What was the disease he discovered he didn't have?

The only malady he could conclude he had not got was housemaid's knee.

He had worked through the whole list of diseases from A to Z and found every other disease in himself.

Housemaid's knee alone was missing from his long list of imaginary complaints.

This single exception became the joke of the whole lesson.

Was he pleased to find he didn't have it?

No, at first he was not pleased at all; he felt rather hurt about it.

It seemed to him a sort of slight, and he asked why he had not got housemaid's

knee and why there should be this invidious reservation.

After a while, however, a less grasping feeling prevailed and he reflected that he had every other known malady.

He then grew less selfish and determined to do without housemaid's knee.

What was his first reaction?

His first reaction was to sit frozen with horror when he realised he had the first disease he read about.

Then, in the listlessness of despair, he turned the pages again and grew interested in his own case.

He determined to sift his case to the bottom and read the book through alphabetically, discovering disease after disease in himself.

At last he sat and pondered what an interesting case he must be from a medical point of view.

Why should he be an acquisition to the medical class?

He thought students would have no need to walk the hospitals if they had him, because he was a hospital in himself.

All they would need to do would be to walk round him and take their diploma, since he contained every disease they had to study.

One living patient displaying every malady would teach the whole class at once.

That is why he called himself an acquisition to the medical class.

Describe his visit to the medical man.

He went to his medical man, an old friend who usually felt his pulse, looked at his tongue and talked about the weather, all for nothing.

This time the doctor opened him and looked down him, clutched hold of his wrist, and hit him over the chest when he was not expecting it.

Immediately afterwards the doctor butted him with the side of his head, a cowardly thing to do, as Jerome calls it.

After that the doctor sat down, wrote out a prescription, folded it up and gave it to him, and Jerome put it in his pocket and went out.

He thought he was doing the doctor good turn by going to him. Why?

He thought that what a doctor wants is practice, and he would give his doctor more practice than seventeen hundred ordinary patients.

Ordinary patients have only one or two diseases each, while he had every disease in the book except housemaid's knee.

So, by offering himself, he was doing the doctor a good turn and giving him a complete medical education in one patient.

The humour lies in his pride at being such a splendid specimen of disease.

What was the prescription given to him by the doctor?

The prescription ran: one pound of beefsteak every six hours.

It also ordered a ten-mile walk every morning and bed at eleven sharp every night.

Its last line was the real medicine: do not stuff your head with things you do not understand.

The doctor thus prescribed good food, exercise, regular sleep and an end to reading medical books.

Describe his visit to the chemist.

He did not open the prescription himself but took it to the nearest chemist and handed it in.

The chemist read it and handed it back, saying that he did not keep it.

Jerome asked in surprise whether he was a chemist, and the man replied that he was a chemist.

He added that if he were a co-operative stores and family hotel combined, he might be able to oblige him, but being only a chemist hampered him.

What is the significance of the doctor's advice: don't stuff your head with things you don't understand?

The advice is the sound moral behind the fantastic exaggeration of the lesson.

Many diseases have common symptoms, so anyone who reads a book on diseases will imagine he has many of them.

Jerome's imaginary illnesses came only from stuffing his head with medical knowledge he did not understand.

The lesson therefore warns us not to read about things beyond our understanding and then worry ourselves sick over them.

Lesson 7: My Financial Career — Stephen Leacock

Comprehension questions

Why was the writer nervous when he entered the bank?

The writer was shy and had never dealt with a bank before.

The grand building, the clerks and the manager frightened him.

He felt that everyone was watching him and judging him.

His nervousness made him behave foolishly throughout the visit.

What mistakes did the writer make in the bank?

He asked to see the manager for a small matter, which was unusual.

He said he wanted to deposit fifty-six dollars but behaved as if it were a fortune.

When asked to write a cheque, he wrote it for fifty-six dollars instead of six.

He then drew out all his money and left the bank in confusion.

What is the humour of 'My Financial Career'?

The humour lies in the contrast between the writer's fear and the simple business.

His nervousness turns an ordinary visit into a series of blunders.

The manager and clerks remain polite, which increases the comedy.

Leacock laughs at his own shyness and at the awe that banks inspire.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What light do the following expressions throw on Leacock's state of mind when he entered the bank: 'looked timidly round', 'shambled in'?

The two expressions show that Leacock entered the bank in a state of nervous fear and embarrassment.

He shambled in, walking badly without lifting his feet enough, like a man who does not know where to go or what to do.

He looked timidly round at the clerks because the grand building and its staff rattled him.

From the very threshold he was, in his own words, an irresponsible idiot whenever he tried to transact business in a bank.

Why did the manager come to think that Leacock had an awful secret to reveal?

Leacock asked to see the manager alone, adding solemnly the word alone, though he did not know why he said it.

His voice was sepulchral, and he held his fifty-six dollars clutched in a crumpled ball in his pocket.

The manager, a grave, calm man, looked at him in some alarm and felt he had an awful secret to reveal.

He therefore led Leacock to a private room, turned the key in the lock, and said they were safe from interruption there.

What was the attitude of the manager towards Leacock on learning that he only wished to deposit 56 dollars in the bank?

At first the manager was relieved that Leacock was not a detective, but still serious, and he concluded Leacock was the son of Baron Rothschild or a young Gould.

When Leacock whispered that he proposed to deposit fifty-six dollars now and fifty dollars a month regularly, the manager's manner changed completely.

He got up, opened the door, and called unkindly loud to the accountant that this

gentleman was opening an account and would deposit fifty-six dollars.

With a cold Good morning he dismissed Leacock, showing that so small a sum was beneath a manager's attention.

What other blunders did Leacock commit after leaving the manager's office?

On leaving the private room he stepped by mistake into the safe, and the manager coldly showed him the other way.

At the accountant's wicket he poked his ball of money at the clerk with a quick convulsive movement, as if doing a conjuring trick.

Then, meaning to draw out only six dollars for present use, he wrote fifty-six on the cheque instead of six.

Too far gone to explain, he recklessly confirmed that he wanted to withdraw every cent of it, and asked for the money in fifties.

After this misadventure in the bank where did Leacock keep his money?

After this misadventure Leacock banked no more.

He kept his money in cash in his trousers pocket.

His savings he kept in silver dollars in a sock.

He thus gave up banks altogether and became his own banker in the most old-fashioned way.

Give as many examples as you can to show that Leacock was feeling completely lost in the bank all the time he was there.

The clerks, the wickets and the sight of the money all rattled him, and the moment he crossed the threshold he became an irresponsible idiot.

He asked to see the manager alone for an ordinary deposit, spoke in a sepulchral voice, and made the manager think he was a detective with an awful secret.

After the manager's office he walked into the safe, poked his money at the accountant like a conjuring trick, and no longer knew what he was doing.

The bank swam before his eyes, he wrote fifty-six instead of six on his cheque, drew

out all his money, and rushed out amid a roar of laughter that followed him to the door.

Lesson 8: China's Way to Progress — Galeazzo Santini

Comprehension questions

How did China make progress according to the lesson?

China made progress through hard work, discipline and planning.

The people worked together for national development.

Agriculture and industry were developed side by side.

Education and science were given great importance.

What lessons can other countries learn from China's progress?

They can learn the value of unity and collective effort.

They can learn to use their own resources wisely.

They can learn that progress needs patience and sacrifice.

Above all, they can learn to rely on themselves rather than on others.

What is the main idea of the lesson?

The lesson shows that a poor country can progress by its own efforts.

China rose from poverty through organisation and hard work.

Its example gives hope to other developing countries.

Progress comes from the people themselves, not from outside help.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

Why has the world changed its attitude towards China?

For twenty-two years China lay forgotten and was even confused with a small island, one of its provinces, while the West kept a curtain of rigid disregard against

her.

Then suddenly one-fourth of mankind, enclosed in the world's third largest country, was brought out of the memory attic with a loud bang.

China introduced the smile policy, but the Western countries certainly launched the warm hug, and crowds of official visitors now make a devoted quasi-pilgrimage to Peking.

The queue of countries waiting to recognise the People's Republic grows longer as the world realises the absurdity of having kept China out of the United Nations for so long.

Discuss Chinese agriculture system.

China remains powerfully agricultural and peasant, and its modernisation has occurred without a flight from the fields, which was the price paid by the West.

The average size of farming concerns is growing through communes, subdivided into production brigades and teams, but the peasant masses stay put and carry on traditional, intensive labour.

Agricultural mechanisation is introduced with considerable caution so as not to upset the balance, and the labourer is kept on the spot and incorporated in local small industries.

Economic decentralisation, perhaps the most important step in Chinese domestic policy since the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution, has freed China from a cumbersome bureaucracy and developed local enterprise to the greatest possible degree of independence.

How does China rely on its own resources?

China relies on its own forces, following Mao's maxim quoted in the Peking People's Daily: rely on your own forces.

National machines and equipment are not entirely indigenous, since they possess a number of foreign features, but they may replace foreign machines because they

are superior to foreign equipment.

They do not require money, or at any rate very little, and are capable of doing great things; indigenous equipment can be promptly prepared when not available.

It can produce bigger, faster, better and cheaper results, and it stimulates the revolutionary spirit of the masses, with which all difficulties can be overcome.

Describe a day in the life of a Chinese student.

The lesson describes Je Wen-Siu, a sixteen-year-old girl who lives in the workers' district of Peng Pu at Shanghai and is a pupil in class 3 at the junior school.

She gets up at six in the morning, does a few chores in the house, has breakfast and goes to school at eight, finishing at eleven.

She goes home for lunch and is back at school at one thirty until three, when she goes home and works.

She does her homework at school, goes through her lessons at home for about an hour, and from four o'clock relaxes, reading papers, listening to the radio, playing sports and ping-pong with friends, and following political news.

Write a note on the Chinese women.

From a Western angle there seems a lack of femininity in the Chinese woman: no beauty products and no mention of sex in films or literature, and drugs are nonexistent.

Mao says that women hold up half the sky, and women are determined to keep their half raised at the same height as that held up by men.

The Chinese woman lists her social benefits: an eight-hour working day, free hospitalisation and medical care, nursery and infant schools, and fifty-six paid days before childbirth, also without charge.

This radical change has given Chinese women a sense of confidence hitherto unknown to them, a dignity and an undoubted awareness of carrying out an important role.

What are the social security benefits provided to the Chinese workers?

The monthly cost of living is officially calculated for every region; in Peking it was recently quoted at twelve to fourteen yuan a month, of which ten go towards board and three to four for rent in State apartments.

All medical and hospital treatment is entirely free for every Chinese worker or peasant, while members of his family pay only fifty per cent, and a sick worker receives his total pay for the first six months, after which he receives sixty per cent.

Workers retire at sixty, female workers at fifty, or fifty-five if they do clerical work, and pensions vary from fifty to seventy per cent of the worker's last wage.

Each factory has a cafeteria where workers eat three meals a day for ten to twelve yuan a month, nearly all plants have nurseries and kindergartens, and an assistance system guarantees a minimum subsistence level.

''It is the people and not the things that are decisive.'' Discuss.

Mao's saying means that China is striving to conceive modernisation as the education and re-education of man, not merely as an increase in GNP.

The heart of the matter is the need to root out selfishness and bring into existence selfless, dedicated men whose happiness consists in serving their fellow-men.

The lesson argues that when a mass of eight hundred million people is not a mere juxtaposition of persons but a compact whole, it tends to become power.

A dollar from each Chinese would make roughly eight hundred million dollars, and a day's work from each would mean two million extra labourers for a year without cost to the State, so people, organised and convinced, are decisive.

''The heart of the matter is the need to root out selfishness.'' Discuss.

The lesson says the gigantic Chinese social experiment is the creation of a new world and a new man, and its heart is rooting out selfishness.

It seeks to prove Thomas Hobbes wrong when he wrote in Leviathan that man's condition is a condition of war of everyone against everyone.

In place of selfishness China wants selfless, dedicated men whose happiness lies in serving their fellow-men in the fullest sense of the human community.

Modernisation is therefore seen as embellishment of the landscape and development of the people's cultural life for the benefit of all, placing the needs of man before those of the machine.

Lesson 9: Hunger and Population Explosion — Anna McKenzie

Comprehension questions

What is the population explosion?

Population explosion is the rapid and uncontrolled growth of population.

It happens when the birth rate is much higher than the death rate.

Medical progress has reduced deaths, but births have not fallen equally.

The world population therefore doubles in a short period.

How does population growth cause hunger?

More people need more food, but farmland does not increase.

Food production cannot keep pace with the growing population.

In poor countries, millions therefore suffer from hunger and malnutrition.

Population control is necessary to solve the food problem.

What solutions does the writer suggest for hunger?

The writer suggests controlling population through family planning.

She also suggests increasing food production by modern farming.

Better distribution of food and education are equally important.

Rich countries should also help poor countries with food and technology.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What does hunger mean on a large scale as viewed by the author?

On a large scale hunger does not mean only the pangs of an empty stomach or a famine in one place.

It means chronic undernourishment and malnutrition affecting millions of people year after year.

It means that large populations live permanently below the level of health because they never get enough food.

The author therefore treats hunger as a world-wide, continuing condition of the poor countries, not as a rare disaster.

Describe some great famines of the past.

The past has seen great famines in which millions died because crops failed and food could not reach the starving people.

In Ireland the failure of the potato crop in the 1840s brought mass starvation and forced millions to emigrate.

In India and Bengal repeated famines in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries killed millions when rains failed and grain was scarce.

In China, too, famine has again and again swept away millions, showing how helpless people were before modern transport and food storage.

How do famines occur?

Famines occur when the food supply of a region falls far below what its people need to live.

Crop failure from drought, flood, pests or war is the commonest cause, since most poor people depend on one harvest.

War, breakdown of transport and hoarding can turn a shortage into a famine by preventing food from reaching the hungry.

When a population already lives on the edge of subsistence, even a small failure of the harvest is enough to bring famine.

What is the main reason for population increase today?

The main reason for population increase today is the sharp fall in the death rate while the birth rate remains high.

Public-health measures, clean water, vaccination and modern medicine now save millions of lives that were formerly lost to disease.

Babies who once died in infancy now survive, and adults live much longer than before.

Because births have not fallen as fast as deaths, the population grows rapidly and doubles in a short period.

What is meant by birth-rate and death-rate and how do they affect the population of a country?

The birth-rate is the number of children born in a year for every thousand people in a population, and the death-rate is the number of deaths per thousand in the same period.

When the birth-rate is higher than the death-rate, the population increases; when it is lower, the population decreases.

If the two rates are equal, the population remains stable.

The gap between a high birth-rate and a falling death-rate is what produces the population explosion in the under-developed countries.

What have public-health measures to do with increase in population?

Public-health measures have everything to do with the increase in population, because they have greatly reduced the death-rate.

Clean drinking water, drainage, vaccination and control of epidemics now prevent the diseases that used to kill millions.

Mothers and babies survive childbirth, children survive fevers and infections, and old people live longer.

Since births continue at the old high rate while deaths fall, public health has

unintentionally become a cause of rapid population growth.

Account for the high birth-rate in under-developed countries.

In under-developed countries children are wanted as extra hands for work in the fields and as support for parents in old age.

Early marriage is common, women marry young and have children over a long period, and family planning is little known or little practised.

Illiteracy, poverty and traditional customs all favour large families, and in many societies a large family is a matter of pride.

Religious and social objections to birth control, together with high infant mortality which makes parents have many children so that some may survive, keep the birth-rate high.

Why is birth rate not so high in the more advanced countries?

In the more advanced countries marriage takes place later, and men and women marry after finishing education and finding work.

Women are educated and many work outside the home, so families are planned and kept small.

The cost of bringing up and educating a child is high, and parents prefer a few well-cared-for children to many.

Family planning is widely known and accepted, infant mortality is low, and old-age pensions remove the need to depend on many children for support.

Give a brief account of the poor economic conditions prevailing in under-developed countries.

The under-developed countries are marked by low incomes, so that most people live at or below subsistence level.

Unemployment and under-employment are widespread, land is scarce and divided into tiny holdings, and farming methods are backward.

Housing is poor, sanitation is bad, schools and hospitals are few, and illiteracy is

common.

Malnutrition, disease and low productivity keep the people poor, and poverty in turn prevents the investment in education, health and industry that could break the circle.

Lesson 10: The Jewel of the World — Philip K. Hitti

Comprehension questions

Why is Cordova called 'The Jewel of the World'?

Cordova, in Muslim Spain, was the most beautiful and learned city of its time.

It had splendid palaces, gardens, libraries and universities.

Scholars from all over Europe came there to study.

Its beauty and learning made it the jewel of the medieval world.

What was the contribution of Muslim Spain to Europe?

Muslim Spain preserved Greek learning and passed it to Europe.

Its scholars advanced medicine, astronomy, mathematics and philosophy.

European students translated Arabic books into Latin in Toledo.

This learning helped to bring about the Renaissance in Europe.

Why did Cordova decline?

Cordova declined because of internal quarrels among Muslim rulers.

The Christian kingdoms of the north grew stronger and attacked it.

Disunity weakened the Muslims and their beautiful city fell.

The lesson is a warning that disunity destroys even great civilisations.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

Give an account of the early career of Abd-al-Rahman I, his dramatic escape and his

adventures in Africa.

Abd-al-Rahman I was a young Umayyad prince who escaped the massacre of his family when the Abbasids overthrew the Umayyad caliphate.

He fled from Syria, hunted by Abbasid agents, and made his way across North Africa, enduring great hardship and danger.

In Africa he wandered among the Berber tribes, winning friends and gathering supporters while his enemies pursued him.

At last he crossed the sea to Spain, where he landed and began the struggle that made him master of Muslim Spain.

How did Abd-al-Rahman deal with the governor appointed by the Abbasid caliph to contest his rule?

The Abbasid caliph sent a governor to Spain to contest Abd-al-Rahman's rule and restore Abbasid authority there.

Abd-al-Rahman met the governor's army in battle and defeated it completely.

He then had the defeated governor killed and his head sent to the Abbasid caliph as a warning.

By this bold act he showed that Spain was no longer subject to Baghdad and that he was its independent ruler.

What did the Abbasid caliph say on receiving the head of his governor?

On receiving the head of his governor the Abbasid caliph was filled with amazement at Abd-al-Rahman's daring.

He marvelled that a lone fugitive, who had escaped his soldiers and crossed Africa, could defeat his governor and send back his head.

In his admiration he called Abd-al-Rahman the falcon of Quraysh, the most daring bird of his tribe.

The caliph's words were thus a tribute from an enemy to the courage and ability of the founder of Umayyad Spain.

What did Abd-al-Rahman do to make himself strong and to beautify his capital?

To make himself strong Abd-al-Rahman built up a powerful army, put down rebellions and organised a firm administration and a regular system of taxation.

He made Cordova his capital and adorned it with splendid buildings, palaces and gardens.

He began the Great Mosque of Cordova, built aqueducts and bridges, and laid out parks and pleasure grounds.

Under him Cordova grew into one of the finest cities of the medieval world, a fitting capital for his kingdom.

Give an account of the all-round progress made by the Arabs under Abd-al-Rahman III.

Under Abd-al-Rahman III, who proclaimed himself caliph in 929, Muslim Spain reached the height of its glory.

Trade flourished, agriculture was developed by irrigation, and industries produced goods that were exported all over the known world.

Learning, art and architecture advanced together: Cordova had hundreds of mosques, schools and libraries, and scholars gathered there from every land.

The caliph's court was the most splendid in Europe, and the progress of the Arabs under him covered government, wealth, science and culture alike.

What did Al-Hakam do to promote learning and scholarship in his kingdom?

Al-Hakam II, the son and successor of Abd-al-Rahman III, was himself a great scholar and lover of books.

He collected a famous library at Cordova containing hundreds of thousands of volumes, and sent agents to distant lands to buy rare manuscripts.

He founded schools and colleges, encouraged poets, historians and scientists, and made Cordova a centre of learning for the whole world.

European students came to Cordova to study, and through its scholars the learning

of the Arabs passed on to the West.

Lesson 11: First Year at Harrow — Sir Winston S. Churchill

Comprehension questions

How did Churchill feel in his first year at Harrow?

Churchill felt unhappy and lonely in his first year at Harrow.

He was weak in Latin and other subjects and ranked low in his class.

He feared examinations and felt he was a failure.

But he loved English, history and poetry, and excelled in them.

What did Churchill learn from his early failure?

He learned that examinations do not measure a boy's real ability.

He discovered his own talents in English and in writing.

He realised that every boy has some gift, even if he fails in some subjects.

His early failure did not prevent him from becoming a great leader.

What is Churchill's opinion about the education system?

Churchill criticises a system that judges boys only by examinations.

He thinks schools should develop each boy's natural talents.

A boy weak in one subject may be strong in another.

Education should aim at character and understanding, not merely marks.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

The writer says that the examiners ask questions which students cannot answer and not those which they can answer. Is the complaint just?

Churchill's complaint is just in the sense that examinations often test what a boy has failed to learn rather than what he knows.

Examiners set questions from the whole syllabus, including the subjects in which a boy is weak, and the boy is judged by his failures.

A boy who is strong in English and history but weak in Latin is therefore marked as a failure, although he has real ability.

The complaint is just because an examination that only exposes weakness, and gives no credit for strength, does not measure a boy's true worth.

What sort of questions are asked by your examiners?

Examiners generally ask questions from the prescribed syllabus, testing memory of facts, grammar and set lessons.

In Churchill's case they asked questions in Latin and Greek which required rote learning of grammar and translation.

Such questions reward the boy who can cram and repeat, and punish the boy whose talent lies in understanding and expression.

The lesson therefore suggests that examination questions should test what a boy can do and understand, not only what he has memorised.

Why did not Churchill do well in examinations?

Churchill did not do well in examinations because he was weak in the subjects on which examinations laid the greatest weight, especially Latin and Greek.

He could not learn by rote, and the endless grammar and translation bored him and would not stay in his head.

His real talents lay in English, history and writing, which the examinations of his day valued little.

He therefore ranked low in his class and felt himself a failure, although he was not dull but differently gifted.

How did he do his Latin paper?

In his Latin paper Churchill made almost no headway at all.

He could answer practically nothing, and his paper remained nearly blank except for

his name and the number of the question.

The paper showed the examiners nothing except that Latin was a closed book to him.

He was therefore placed in the lowest form, a result that seemed to confirm his failure but in fact only showed his weakness in one subject.

Churchill was taught English at Harrow and not Latin and Greek. Was it a gain or loss?

It was a great gain, not a loss, that Churchill was taught English at Harrow instead of Latin and Greek.

Placed in the lowest division, he was taught English thoroughly by Mr Somervell, who made him parse sentences, analyse language and write essays.

He thus gained a complete mastery of his own language, the weapon he needed all his life.

Latin and Greek might have given him classical learning, but English gave him the power to write and speak, and to earn his living by his pen.

What good did his three years stay at Harrow do him?

His three years at Harrow gave him a thorough grounding in English, which became the foundation of his whole career.

Under Mr Somervell he learned to write clear, forceful English, to understand the structure of sentences and to express ideas exactly.

He also learned history and poetry, which fed his imagination and his sense of the past.

Harrow therefore did him the good of teaching him what he could learn well, instead of wasting his years on subjects in which he could not succeed.

In after years how did the knowledge of English stand him in good stead?

In after years his knowledge of English stood him in good stead in every part of his career.

As a soldier, journalist and writer he earned his living by his pen, writing books and articles that were read all over the world.

As a statesman he moved nations by his speeches, which were powerful because they were written in clear, vivid English.

English, learned in the lowest form at Harrow, thus became the instrument of his fame and of his service to his country.

Write an appreciation or criticism of Churchill's views in regard to the study of Latin, Greek and English and their value in earning a living.

Churchill's view is that Latin and Greek, though valuable as culture, are of little practical use in earning a living.

A boy may spend years on dead languages and still be unable to write a clear letter or make a speech in his own tongue.

English, on the other hand, is the language in which a man must work, write, argue and persuade, and mastery of it is a practical asset for life.

Churchill is right to criticise a system that prizes classics above the mother tongue, though Latin and Greek have their own cultural value which he does not deny.

Lesson 12: Hitch-Hiking Across the Sahara — G. F. Lamb

Comprehension questions

Why did the writer decide to hitch-hike across the Sahara?

The writer wanted adventure and wished to see the great desert.

He had little money, so he decided to travel by lifts.

He believed that strangers would help a lonely traveller.

His journey became a test of courage, patience and trust.

What difficulties did the writer face in the Sahara?

He faced burning heat during the day and bitter cold at night.

Water and food were scarce, and lifts were rare.

Sandstorms blinded him and made travel dangerous.

Loneliness and fear also troubled him in the vast empty desert.

What did the writer learn from his journey?

He learned that human kindness exists even in the harshest places.

Drivers, nomads and villagers helped him with food and shelter.

He learned to endure hardship and to trust others.

The journey taught him more about life than books could.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

Give an idea of the size of the Sahara. How does it compare with England?

The Sahara stretches almost the complete width of North Africa and is many times the size of Great Britain.

If a giant were to pick England up and put it down in the middle of the Sahara desert, we should have quite a task to find it.

About half of this gigantic area was, at the time of the lesson, mainly under French control.

Its vastness, with immense stretches of barren sand, few water wells and little vegetation, is what makes crossing it so formidable.

What had Christopher's fostermother to do with his desire to see distant places?

When Christopher was a child, every time he was naughty his foster-mother used to threaten to send him to Timbuktu.

Timbuktu was an ancient city in the heart of French Africa, and the threat was meant to frighten him.

Instead of alarming him, the idea aroused in him a keen desire to see this distant place.

The foster-mother's threat therefore planted the wanderlust in him, and by the time he was a young man he was firmly gripped by the desire to travel.

How did he manage to get a seat in the weapons carrier?

Christopher stopped a fast-moving weapons carrier which overtook his slow desert truck and begged the lieutenant in charge to relieve him from slowly baking to death at twenty miles an hour.

The lieutenant pointed out that strict military regulations forbade the carrying of civilians.

Christopher replied by producing a permit from the War Ministry giving him permission to join the French Foreign Legion for a short period to collect material for an article.

The permission had later been withdrawn, but fortunately the lieutenant did not turn the paper over and see the cancelled stamp, so Christopher got his seat.

What was the most noticeable feature of the desert city, named Ghardaia?

The most noticeable feature of Ghardaia, a typical desert city, was its flies, which were even more numerous and stickier than anywhere else.

Anything that had the remotest relationship with food was constantly and completely covered with flies.

The flies followed food right into one's mouth, and Christopher had to be vigilant until each mouthful was safely behind his teeth.

He saw many children on the streets but got only a vague idea of what they looked like, for they all wore a mask of flies.

How did they manage to drive the heavy truck in the trackless desert with its soft sand?

When the road stopped, the driver, Hantout, picked his way across the trackless desert with uncanny skill.

At times the sand became too soft to bear the weight of the heavy ten-ton truck,

and it was necessary to stop at once, lest the wheels spin and dig themselves deeper.

Ten-foot strips of steel mesh were dragged from the truck and placed together to make a runway for the wheels to bite on as the truck moved.

When harder ground was reached the strips were collected up and dragged forward to the waiting truck, Christopher helping the greaser in this arduous operation.

What did the driver of the truck tell Christopher about three Englishmen who had attempted to cross the desert?

The driver, Hantout, told Christopher of a recent case in which three English people had attempted to cross part of the desert in a car with only one day's water supply. Their car became stuck in a sand dune, and three days later their bodies were found dried up like leaves.

They had drained the radiator in their desperate thirst, and one of them had tried to drain the oil from the crank-case.

Hantout had been one of the search party, and he spared his listener none of the grim details.

Give an account of the little town, named El Golea, and compare it with In Salah, bringing out the difference between the two.

El Golea, a hundred miles on, was a fascinating little town, a true oasis with so much water available that the people hardly knew what to do with it.

Every day of the week he was there Christopher spent hours bathing in a little pool half a kilometre from the centre, shaded by palm and fruit trees, or lying on the cool grass watching birds feast on the dates.

In Salah differs sharply: it is fighting a desperate battle for survival and perhaps losing the contest, for the sand is constantly encroaching on the town.

Parts of In Salah are being swallowed by the desert, and in spite of every effort to hold it back, the desert keeps tightening its strangle-hold, so that El Golea has

triumphed over the desert while In Salah is being conquered by it.

What do you know of Professor Claude Balanguermon?

Professor Claude Balanguermon was a remarkable Frenchman whom Christopher met at Tamanrasset, and one of his most valuable contacts.

He had devoted himself to helping the Tuareg people and had succeeded in convincing them that education would be useful to them.

Most wisely, he adapted himself to their habits and customs so that he could help them get the most from their own natural way of life, rather than persuade them to adopt Western habits unsuited to their land and traditions.

He acted as Christopher's guide, host and friend in Tamanrasset, arranged his stay in the encampment of the Tuareg Amenokal, and sent the guide Boubaker with him on the road to Timbuktu.

Describe the events leading to the killing of a camel. What sort of water did they get from its stomach?

On the way to Kidal the party found well after well bone-dry; at last they had neither food nor water, only one tin of food shared among four men and water down to one litre.

There was just one chance of survival: one of the six camels could be killed, and Christopher willingly agreed to pay his share of the cost.

As soon as a camel was picked for slaughter it seemed to know what was to happen and started screaming at the top of its voice.

When the victim was killed, the liquid in its stomach was caught in a water-bag by the slave: a greenish fluid, like thin blood, the least appetizing drink imaginable, which even the Tuaregs drank with faces, and which Christopher could only drink boiled, holding his nose.

Describe the journey through the land of Thirst and Death.

The region through which they were passing was known as the Land of Thirst and

Death, and the name was well chosen, for it was notorious for sandstorms as well as for dried-up waterholes.

Shortly after the midday stop the camels turned off their course to a depression in the sand, and a sandstorm struck with a wall of sand streaming along the earth. Christopher crouched behind his camel while the wind found even the smallest opening in his clothes and the sand piled up on him; the storm lasted half an hour and left seventy-five millimetres of sand covering them all.

Beyond Kidal there were still over four hundred and fifty kilometres of grim desert, the loneliest and most arduous stage of the crossing, until at last he caught his first glimpse of Timbuktu after a journey of thirty-two hundred kilometres.

Describe the stay at In Abbangarit. How did Christopher manage to get water there?

There is no village at In Abbangarit; the only building is a bordj, a simple mud structure of a roof and four walls, with one hole for a window and another for a door, and the well is about two hundred and seventy-five metres away.

When Christopher reached the well he had a shock: there was water there, but it was forty-six metres below, and there was neither rope nor bucket.

His only container was a small metal teapot holding about half a cupful at a time, and after fastening together all his bits of cord and clothing, and tearing his turban into four strips, he still reached only halfway down.

Then he had an inspiration: his battery-operated recording machine used thin wire as its recording medium, about three hundred and five metres long, and seven strands twisted together just reached the water, so he drew up teapot after teapot of water and survived.

Lesson 13: Sir Alexander Fleming — Patrick Pringle

Comprehension questions

What great discovery did Fleming make?

Fleming discovered penicillin, the first antibiotic drug.

He noticed that a mould growing on a culture plate killed bacteria around it.

He identified the mould as Penicillium and its juice as penicillin.

Penicillin later saved millions of lives from bacterial infections.

How did Fleming's discovery happen?

It happened partly by chance and partly by careful observation.

A mould spore fell by accident on a bacterial culture plate.

Fleming noticed the clear area where bacteria had been destroyed.

Instead of throwing the plate away, he studied it and made his discovery.

What qualities of Fleming does the lesson show?

Fleming was patient, observant and devoted to research.

He worked for years without seeking fame or fortune.

He shared his discovery freely for the good of mankind.

His humility and hard work made him a great scientist.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What are antiseptics and what is the antiseptic method?

Antiseptics are chemical substances which kill germs on wounds and prevent infection.

The antiseptic method, introduced by Lister, was to treat wounds and dressings with carbolic acid so that germs could not enter and multiply.

Surgeons sprayed carbolic acid in the operating theatre and soaked dressings in it, and the death rate from infected wounds fell sharply.

It was the first great attempt to fight the germs that cause wound infection by chemical means.

What was the chief defect of antiseptic method?

The chief defect of the antiseptic method was that the antiseptics killed the living cells of the body as well as the germs.

Carbolic acid and similar chemicals destroyed the tissues round a wound and so hindered the natural healing of the body.

They also could not reach germs that had already gone deep into the tissues.

The method therefore checked infection only at the surface, while damaging the very tissues it was meant to save.

What part is played by the white cells in the blood of a human body?

The white cells in the blood are the body's own soldiers against disease.

They gather at the seat of infection, surround the germs and devour them, a process called phagocytosis.

They also produce substances that destroy germs and help to wall off infection by forming pus.

Fleming's work on penicillin grew out of his interest in these natural defences, since he wanted a substance that would help, not hinder, the white cells.

Give an account of the early life of Fleming.

Alexander Fleming was born in 1881 at Lochfield, a farm in Ayrshire in Scotland, the son of a farmer.

He was educated at local schools and at Kilmarnock Academy, and then came to London, where he worked for some years as a shipping clerk.

On the advice of his brother he entered St Mary's Hospital Medical School to study medicine, and there he proved a brilliant student.

He joined the staff of St Mary's, worked under Sir Almroth Wright on vaccines and immunity, and served as a doctor in the First World War, where infected wounds set him thinking about antiseptics.

Describe how Fleming discovered penicillin.

In 1928 Fleming was working at St Mary's on staphylococcus germs grown on culture plates.

One plate had become contaminated by a mould spore that had floated in through the window, and round the mould the germs had been dissolved, leaving a clear zone.

Instead of throwing the plate away, Fleming studied it and found that the mould, Penicillium notatum, gave out a juice which killed many kinds of germs.

He called this juice penicillin, and thus, by chance joined to careful observation, one of the greatest discoveries in medicine was made.

In what respect is penicillin better than the chemical antiseptics?

Penicillin is better than the chemical antiseptics because it kills germs without harming the cells of the body.

Chemical antiseptics destroy living tissue as well as germs and therefore hinder healing, but penicillin leaves the white cells unharmed.

It acts even in very weak dilutions and can reach germs inside the body through the blood.

It is therefore a natural antibiotic, not a poison, and can be used safely inside the body where antiseptics could never go.

What do you know of the Oxford team?

The Oxford team was led by Professor Howard Florey, with Dr Ernst Chain and Mr Norman Heatley working with him.

They took up Fleming's discovery, which had lain unused for ten years, and set themselves to purify penicillin and test it.

Working in difficult wartime conditions, they extracted penicillin in pure form and proved by experiments on mice and then on men that it cured infections.

Without the Oxford team's patient chemical and medical work, Fleming's mould juice would never have become a usable drug.

How did they make penicillin more effective?

They made penicillin more effective by purifying it and concentrating it, so that a small dose contained great germ-killing power.

Heatley devised a method of extracting penicillin from the mould culture and of measuring its strength.

They then worked out how to produce it in larger quantities and how to give it by injection so that it reached the infected tissues.

Clinical trials showed that purified penicillin, given regularly, could cure septicaemia, pneumonia and infected wounds that had formerly been fatal.

Write a note on penicillin as a wonder drug.

Penicillin is called a wonder drug because it transformed the treatment of bacterial disease within a few years.

Wounds that would have become gangrenous, pneumonia, blood poisoning, meningitis and syphilis all yielded to it.

In the Second World War it saved the lives of countless soldiers with infected wounds, and in peace it saved mothers from childbed fever and children from deadly infections.

It opened the age of antibiotics and added many years to the average length of human life, which is why it is justly called a wonder drug.

Was Fleming proud of his discovery?

No, Fleming was not proud of his discovery; he remained modest about it all his life.

He always said that he did not invent penicillin, nature did, and that his part was only to notice what the mould had done.

He gave the credit freely to the Oxford team who purified it and to the workers who produced it in quantity.

His humility, and his refusal to seek fame or fortune from his discovery, are among the finest qualities the lesson shows in him.

Why couldn't penicillin have been discovered in the research laboratories of America?

Penicillin could not have been discovered in the highly organised research laboratories of America because it was not the product of a planned programme. It came from an accidental contamination of a culture plate in a small, untidy laboratory, noticed by a man with the eye to see its meaning.

American laboratories were organised for routine, team research, where a contaminated plate would simply have been thrown away.

Fleming's discovery therefore needed the freedom, the mess and the observant mind of a small laboratory, not a great research machine.

Fleming's achievement paved the way for other discoveries in the medical field. What are they?

Fleming's achievement paved the way for the whole family of antibiotics that followed penicillin.

Streptomycin was discovered for tuberculosis, and aureomycin, terramycin and other antibiotics followed for many infections.

The sulpha drugs and modern chemotherapy grew in the same climate of research into germ-killing substances.

Above all, Fleming's work established the idea that nature itself provides weapons against germs, and that idea has guided medical research ever since.

Lesson 14: Louis Pasteur — Margaret Avery

Comprehension questions

What did Pasteur discover about germs?

Pasteur proved that germs cause fermentation and disease.

He showed that germs come from other germs, not from nothing.

His experiments disproved the theory of spontaneous generation.

He also showed that heat can kill germs, the process called pasteurisation.

How did Pasteur help the silk and wine industries?

Silkworms were dying of disease, and wine was turning sour.

Pasteur found that germs caused both troubles.

He advised cleanliness and heating to kill the germs.

His advice saved the silk industry of France and improved wine-making.

What was Pasteur's greatest service to mankind?

Pasteur developed vaccines against anthrax and rabies.

His rabies vaccine saved the life of a boy bitten by a mad dog.

He founded the Pasteur Institute for research and treatment.

His work laid the foundations of modern medicine and surgery.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

Describe the early life of Pasteur.

Louis Pasteur was born in 1822 at Dole in France, the son of a tanner who had served as a soldier under Napoleon.

As a boy he was fond of drawing and was not remarkable at school, but he worked hard and won a place at the Ecole Normale in Paris.

He became a teacher of chemistry and physics, and then professor at Strasbourg and at Lille, where his work on fermentation began.

His early life thus shows a humble, hard-working student rising by patience and devotion to become the greatest scientist of his age.

Give some instances of Pasteur's patriotism.

Pasteur's patriotism showed itself in his refusal of German honours after the Franco-Prussian War, when he returned the honorary degree given him by the

University of Bonn.

During the war he worked to help his country, and after it he devoted his science to French industries, saving the wine, beer and silk trades.

He refused to accept money or honours from Germany and declared that science has no country, but the scientist must have one.

His Pasteur Institute in Paris was itself a gift to France, and his whole life was service to his nation as well as to mankind.

What do we mean by spontaneous generation?

By spontaneous generation we mean the old belief that living things can arise by themselves from non-living matter.

It was believed that maggots arise from rotting meat, that mice arise from dirty rags, and that germs arise from broth left standing.

According to this theory, life is continually being created afresh out of dead matter without parents.

Pasteur's experiments were designed to test this belief and, in the end, to disprove it.

How did Pasteur prove that spontaneous generation was not a fact?

Pasteur proved it by his famous swan-neck flask experiments.

He boiled broth in flasks with long, curved necks, so that air could enter but dust, carrying germs, settled in the bend and could not reach the broth.

The broth in these flasks remained clear and lifeless for months, although air had free access to it.

When the neck was broken off and dust allowed to fall in, the broth quickly swarmed with germs, proving that germs come from other germs in the air, not from the broth itself.

Describe the importance and popularity of the silkworm industry in France. What help did Pasteur render in curing the silkworm disease in his country?

The silkworm industry was of immense importance in France, giving work to thousands and producing the silk for which France was famous all over the world.

In the 1860s a terrible disease, pebrine, followed by flacherie, attacked the silkworms and threatened to ruin the whole industry.

Pasteur studied the disease and found that it was caused by tiny germs passed from moth to egg.

He advised breeders to destroy every infected moth and keep only eggs from healthy moths, and by this simple method the industry was saved and restored to prosperity.

How did Pasteur discover the treatment for the cattle disease, Anthrax?

Anthrax was a deadly cattle disease that killed sheep and cattle in great numbers and sometimes attacked men as well.

Pasteur found that it was caused by a rod-shaped germ, and that animals could be protected by inoculation with a weakened form of the germ.

He weakened the anthrax germs by growing them at a high temperature, so that they lost their virulence but still taught the body to resist.

At Pouilly-le-Fort in 1881 he publicly vaccinated sheep with his anthrax vaccine, and while the unvaccinated sheep died, the vaccinated lived, proving his treatment.

How did Pasteur discover the method of making vaccines?

Pasteur discovered the method of making vaccines by studying chicken cholera, when an old, forgotten culture was used by accident.

Chickens inoculated with the old, weakened culture became ill but recovered, and afterwards resisted a fresh, strong dose that killed unprotected birds.

He realised that a germ weakened by age, heat or air could give protection without causing the full disease.

This principle of attenuation, of weakening the germ to make a safe vaccine, became the basis of all his later vaccines and of modern preventive medicine.

Give an account of Pasteur's treatment of Hydrophobia and how he cured the first patient suffering from it.

Hydrophobia, or rabies, is the terrible disease caused by the bite of a mad dog, and in Pasteur's day it was always fatal.

Pasteur prepared a vaccine by passing the virus through rabbits and drying the infected spinal cords, so that the virus grew weaker day by day.

In 1885 a boy, Joseph Meister, bitten badly by a rabid dog, was brought to him, and Pasteur gave him a series of injections of increasing strength over ten days.

The boy lived, and the cure astonished the world, bringing sufferers from every country to Paris and leading to the founding of the Pasteur Institute.

How did Pasteur show the way to other scientists? Give an account of the discoveries.

Pasteur showed the way to other scientists by establishing the germ theory of disease and fermentation.

Lister, following Pasteur, introduced antiseptic surgery, and surgeons learned to kill germs before they entered wounds.

Other scientists, following his vaccine principle, made vaccines against cholera, typhoid, diphtheria and tetanus.

His work on pasteurisation, the heating of milk and wine to kill germs, and his founding of the Pasteur Institute, made him the father of modern microbiology and preventive medicine.

Lesson 15: Mustafa Kamal — Wilfrid F. Castle

Comprehension questions

Who was Mustafa Kamal? What did he achieve?

Mustafa Kamal, later Ataturk, was the founder of modern Turkey.

He led the Turks against foreign occupation after the First World War.

He won independence and established the Turkish Republic.

He then reformed Turkey into a modern, secular nation.

What reforms did Mustafa Kamal introduce in Turkey?

He abolished the Caliphate and separated religion from the state.

He gave women equal rights, including the right to vote.

He replaced Arabic script with the Latin alphabet for Turkish.

He introduced Western dress, law and education in Turkey.

What qualities made Mustafa Kamal a great leader?

He was brave, determined and far-sighted.

He loved his country and worked selflessly for its freedom.

He was a soldier, a statesman and a reformer in one.

His leadership transformed a defeated empire into a proud republic.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What was the attitude of the Turkish government towards the Allies after World War I?

After the First World War the Turkish government at Istanbul, under Sultan Mehmed VI, adopted an attitude of submission towards the Allies.

It accepted the Allied occupation of Istanbul and the partition of the Ottoman Empire, and it obeyed Allied orders.

The Sultan's government hoped to save the throne by cooperating with the victors, even at the cost of the country's independence.

This submissive attitude angered the Turkish patriots, who refused to accept a peace that dismembered their homeland.

Why was Mustafa Kamal sent to Anatolia?

Mustafa Kamal was sent to Anatolia officially to supervise the disbanding of the Turkish army and to restore order there.

The Sultan's government, acting under Allied pressure, wanted the remaining Turkish forces in Anatolia dissolved.

Kamal was chosen as inspector of the army in Anatolia because of his reputation as a soldier.

In fact, once in Anatolia, he used his mission to organise the national resistance instead of carrying out the Sultan's orders.

What was the reaction of the Turkish patriots to the intention of the Allies to partition the Ottoman Empire?

The Turkish patriots reacted with anger and determination against the Allied intention to partition the Ottoman Empire.

They refused to accept a settlement that would give Smyrna to Greece, large areas to France and Italy, and leave Turkey a small state round Istanbul.

National congresses at Erzurum and Sivas declared that the country must remain whole and that the nation itself would decide its fate.

The patriots rallied round Mustafa Kamal and prepared to resist the partition by force of arms.

Write a note on Mustafa Kamal's activities in Anatolia.

In Anatolia Mustafa Kamal organised the national movement from nothing into a powerful force.

He called the congresses of Erzurum and Sivas, which united the patriots and declared the national will.

He set up the Grand National Assembly at Ankara in 1920, which became the government of the national resistance.

He raised and trained an army, directed the War of Independence against the Greeks and the Allies, and laid the foundations of the new Turkish Republic.

Why did Mehmed order Mustafa Kamal to return to Constantinople?

Mehmed ordered Mustafa Kamal to return to Constantinople because he feared Kamal's growing power in Anatolia.

The Sultan saw that Kamal was not disbanding the army but organising a national movement that challenged the authority of Istanbul.

Under Allied pressure, and wishing to keep control of the country, Mehmed dismissed Kamal from his post and ordered him back.

The order was meant to remove the leader of the resistance and to break the national movement before it grew stronger.

What was Mustafa Kamal's reply?

Mustafa Kamal's reply was to resign from the army rather than obey the order to return.

He gave up his rank and uniform so that the Sultan could no longer command him as an officer.

As a civilian he continued to lead the national movement with even greater freedom.

His reply thus turned dismissal into defiance, and showed that he would serve the nation, not the Sultan's government.

How did Mehmed try to regain Anatolia for himself?

Mehmed tried to regain Anatolia by sending his own forces against the nationalists and by relying on the Allies.

The government at Istanbul issued decrees against Kamal, raised an army of its own, and sought Allied help to crush Ankara.

It also used religious authority against the nationalists, declaring them rebels against the Caliph.

But the people of Anatolia supported Kamal, the Sultan's forces failed, and Istanbul lost all authority over the interior of the country.

Why did his plan fail?

Mehmed's plan failed because the nation stood behind Mustafa Kamal and not behind the Sultan.

The people of Anatolia had suffered under occupation and partition, and they trusted Kamal's leadership and his army.

The Sultan's forces were weak, divided and without popular support, while the national army grew stronger every month.

Above all, the victories of the national army over the Greeks destroyed the last hope of Istanbul, and the Sultan's authority collapsed.

What were the terms offered to Turkey by the Allies?

The terms offered to Turkey by the Allies were contained in the Treaty of Sevres of 1920.

Turkey was to lose Smyrna and western Anatolia to Greece, large areas in the south to France and Italy, and the Arab provinces altogether.

The Turkish army was to be limited to a small force, the Straits were to be internationalised, and Turkey was to pay heavy reparations.

In effect Turkey would have become a small, dependent state, and it was these terms that the national movement refused to accept.

Give an account of the Greek attack and its defeat.

The Greeks, encouraged by the Allies, landed at Smyrna in 1919 and advanced deep into Anatolia, hoping to destroy the national movement.

At first they made progress, but Mustafa Kamal organised the Turkish army and halted them at the Battle of Sakarya in 1921.

In August 1922 he launched a great counter-offensive at Dumlupinar, broke the Greek lines and drove the Greek army in rout to the sea.

Smyrna was recovered, the Greek invasion was destroyed, and Turkey's victory forced the Allies to make a new and honourable peace at Lausanne.

Give an account of the departure of Mehmed from Istanbul.

When the national army triumphed, the Sultanate was abolished by the Grand National Assembly in November 1922.

Mehmed VI, deserted by his ministers and fearing for his life, left Istanbul secretly.

He fled on a British warship, abandoning his capital, his throne and his country.

His departure marked the end of the Ottoman dynasty and the final victory of the national movement under Mustafa Kamal.

Describe the reforms introduced by Mustafa Kamal with reference to: (i) the position of women, (ii) removal of illiteracy, (iii) change in dresses, (iv) adoption of the Roman script and (v) the industrial and economic development.

For women, Mustafa Kamal gave them equal rights with men: they were unveiled, educated, admitted to professions and given the vote.

For illiteracy, he opened schools everywhere, made primary education free and compulsory, and himself taught the new alphabet to the people.

For dress, he abolished the fez and the veil and introduced Western dress, so that Turks dressed like modern Europeans.

For script, he replaced the Arabic script with the Roman script in 1928, making Turkish easy to read and learn.

For industry and economy, he built railways, factories, banks and mines, encouraged agriculture and trade, and laid the foundations of a modern national economy.

Sum up in a few sentences the work of Mustafa Kamal as a great nation-builder.

Mustafa Kamal saved Turkey from partition and foreign occupation and made it an independent republic.

He abolished the Sultanate and the Caliphate, separated religion from the state, and gave Turkey a modern constitution.

He reformed education, law, dress, script and the position of women, and built up

industry and agriculture.

As soldier, statesman and reformer he transformed a defeated empire into a proud, modern nation, and for this he is rightly called Ataturk, the father of the Turks.

Lesson 16: A Dialogue — Usman Naveed

Comprehension questions — superseded — dialogue mismatch

What is the dialogue about?

The dialogue is a conversation between two friends about life and studies.

One friend is worried about his future and his examinations.

The other advises him to work hard and have faith in himself.

It shows how friendly advice can remove fear and give courage.

What advice is given in the dialogue?

The friend advises regular study instead of last-minute cramming.

He says success comes from patience, discipline and honest work.

He advises the worried friend not to compare himself with others.

He reminds him that failure is not the end, but a lesson for the future.

What is the main lesson of 'A Dialogue'?

The lesson teaches the value of true friendship and good counsel.

It shows that worries decrease when shared with a friend.

It encourages students to face examinations with confidence.

Hard work, hope and self-belief are the keys to success.

Book exercise — Answer these questions (verbatim, complete)

What type of news was there in the newspaper?

The newspaper carried news of another incident of child abuse in that very week.

Farasat, reading the newspaper in the college library, exclaimed at the fresh incident, and Saleem took the paper in alarm.

The news was of the tragic kind that had led to mass protest, and it left both students sad and thoughtful.

It was this news that started the whole discussion with their teacher about the menace of child abuse.

Why did Farasat and Saleem become sad after reading the news?

Farasat and Saleem became sad because the news told of a child who had suffered abuse, one more in a series of tragic incidents.

They were shocked that such cruelty could happen in their own city and to innocent children.

Their teacher found them sitting pensively in the library, quite dejected, and asked whether everything was all right.

Their sadness was the natural pity of young men faced with the suffering of children who cannot defend themselves.

Describe the four categories of the child abuse.

The teacher explains that child abuse means maltreatment of a child and can be categorised into four categories.

The first is neglect, when a child is left without food, care or protection.

The second is emotional abuse, when a child is frightened, humiliated or denied love.

The third is physical abuse, when a child is beaten or injured, and the fourth is sexual abuse, when a child is used for sexual purposes.

How can we overcome child abuse?

Child abuse can be overcome by the combined effort of the family, the school, the government and society.

Parents should give their children love, care, education and a safe home, and

teachers should watch for signs of abuse and report them.

The government should strengthen child protection institutions, enforce the law against abusers, and give free and compulsory education.

Above all, people must gain knowledge about the problem, share information, and strive to create a world in which children only need to focus on living happily.

What are the basic rights of children in Islam?

In Islam children are regarded as gifts and a trust from Allah, and Islam pays particular attention to their rights.

Children have the right to be fed, clothed and protected until they reach adulthood.

The child has the right to good education and a stable environment in which to grow.

The teacher closes the dialogue with a hadith of the Holy Prophet, that he is not one of us who does not have mercy on our young ones and does not respect our elders.

What are the threats to the children living in war-zones of the world?

Children living near war-zones face many threats, beginning with child casualties from explosive weapons, which children mistake for toys.

Explosives limit access to safe places for children and their families, and children as young as eight join military groups, forced by poverty, to defend their community or for revenge.

Refugee and migrant children face kidnapping, and many become slaves, soldiers and drug traffickers.

Lack of access to quality education is another threat, and extreme poverty brings malnutrition and stunting in the new generation.

How can parents, teachers and media perform their duties to eliminate this evil of child abuse from the society?

Parents should get their children educated and consider it the top priority of their life, for educating a girl child is educating a nation.

Teachers can play a very important role in reporting child abuse, teaching youngsters that danger may lurk among people they love and trust, and alerting parents.

The media is equally involved in eliminating child abuse and promoting a conducive environment for child safety, and social media, though it changes communication, must be watched by parents for its good and bad effects on children.

The government should strengthen institutions such as families of children in vulnerable circumstances, social welfare departments and law enforcement agencies, so that a teacher who sees bruises can report to social welfare, which investigates before reporting to the law and ultimately to the court.